

Linguistic Analysis of Police Interrogation Methods: Understanding the Phenomenon of False Confessions

By

Majed bin Fahd bin Jaban Al-Anzi

Master's Researcher – Department of English Language and Literature

Faculty of Arts – Mansoura University

Under the supervision of

Prof. Dr. Hamdy Mohamed Mohamed Shaheen

Professor of Applied Linguistics, Faculty of Arts, Mansoura University

Abstract:

Interactions among language, law enforcement and courts in police interview settings are topics that have important effects on criminal justice results and are often studied by forensic linguists. Lying about an offense they did not commit puts justice systems worldwide in a difficult situation and how the lie is told is deeply influenced by language aspects. It investigates the way interrogation practices by police may lead to false confessions by examining careful records of interviews to understand which parts of the conversation are linked to false admissions.

Keywords: Interactions between language, justice, and linguistic analysis; they observe false confessions.

التحليل اللغوي لأساليب استجواب الشرطة: فهم ظاهرة الاعترافات الكاذبة

إعداد

ماجد بن فهد بن جبان العنزي

باحث ماجستير – قسم اللغة الإنجليزية وآدابها

كلية الآداب – جامعة المنصورة

تحت إشراف

أ.د/ حمدي محمد محمد شاهين

أستاذ اللغويات التطبيقية المتفرغ

كلية الآداب – جامعة المنصورة

المستخلص:

تُعدّ التفاعلات بين اللغة وهيئات إنفاذ القانون والمحاكم في سياقات مقابلات الشرطة مواضيع ذات تأثيرات مهمة على نتائج العدالة الجنائية، وكثيرًا ما يدرسها اللغويون الشرعيون. إن الكذب بشأن جريمة لم يرتكبوها يضع أنظمة العدالة حول العالم في موقف صعب، كما أن كيفية الكذب تتأثر بشدة بالجوانب اللغوية. يبحث هذا البحث في كيفية تسبب ممارسات الاستجواب التي تتبعها الشرطة في اعترافات كاذبة، وذلك من خلال فحص سجلات المقابلات بدقة لفهم أي أجزاء من المحادثة ترتبط بالاعترافات الكاذبة.

الكلمات المفتاحية:

التفاعلات بين اللغة، العدالة الجنائية، التحليل اللغوي، فهم ظاهرة الاعترافات الكاذبة.

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Introduction

Interactions among language, law enforcement and courts in police interview settings are topics that have important effects on criminal justice results and are often studied by forensic linguists. Lying about an offense they did not commit puts justice systems worldwide in a difficult situation and how the lie is told is deeply influenced by language aspects. It investigates the way interrogation practices by police may lead to false confessions by examining careful records of interviews to understand which parts of the conversation are linked to false admissions.

The importance of this research is that individuals who are falsely convicted usually end up making confessions on the crimes they did not commit. New statistics released by the Innocence Project indicate that roughly 25 percent of cases where DNA exonerated the mistakenly convicted included false confessions. This suggests a weakness of the existing techniques of questioning. The thing about false confessions is that it is more widespread than you may think. The cause of them is the manner of conducting interrogations and the environment of interrogation (Kassin et al., 2025, p. 8). The linguistic peculiarities of these theories can be improved successfully when they are comprehended in detail.

The research falls within the field of forensic linguistics that enables the use of linguistic processes to be applied to the law. Previously, the psychology of false confessions (Gudjonsson, 2018) as well as policies aimed at their prevention (Leo, 2009) have been examined. This paper employs discourse analysis to describe how language influences power and it also helps to keep investigations on course in certain instances.

I observe the formation of meaning, its contestation and even alteration, relying on the critical discourse analysis of Fairclough (2020), the pragmatic theory of Levinson (2023) and the narrative analysis of police interviewing

suggested by Labov (2020). By doing so, it is simpler to understand how even minute components of language can influence the overall results of criminal justice. It is devoted to the research questions including:

1. What features of conversation are seen in police interrogations and what makes them different in the cases where false confessions are admitted versus those where either true confessions or no confessions happen?
2. How can interrogators use various techniques of language to question suspects and these techniques can influence or hinder what the suspects say.
3. How do the different uses of language reveal the balance of authority in an interrogation and what effect does this have on getting confessions?
4. How can some features of the manner in which individuals speak lead to false confessing and how can we define and deal with them during interviews?

The detailed analysis done for these questions aims to support both scholarly study and better practical techniques for questioning people, so that the criminal justice system strikes a good balance between investigation effectiveness and respect for rights.

Literature Review

The Field of Forensic Linguistics and Interrogation Discourse

In the past ten years, there have been significant developments in the application of linguistics in police interrogations and recent advances in corpus linguistics has given researchers more techniques to examine cases of this nature. As Eggington (2023) observes, large-scale corpus studies have the potential to identify language patterns of interrogation, which might be missed in the traditional qualitative analysis. With its help, it is possible to analyze a great number of examples and outline regularities in the formation of questions, permission of answers and background elaboration.

Starting with this framework, Haworth (2023) looks into how interrogation talks turn into transcripts, pointing out that the tools and methods involved

can alter the original conversation. Her work on the "For the Record" project demonstrates that seemingly minor transcription decisions can fundamentally change the interpretation of interrogation discourse, potentially obscuring linguistic indicators of coercion or contamination (p. 3). Because of this discovery, both audio recordings and written transcripts should be studied when analyzing interrogation conversations.

In his work, Heydon (2020) considers police interrogations to be events where elements of conversation, institutional behavior and strategy are all present (p. ٤٥). Because of the hybridity, the setting becomes intricate and rules for conversations are set aside, even though the suspect might not realize it. Filipović (٢٠٢١) further looks at how police interviews are difficult because of this hybridity and suggests techniques that involve understanding how language is used.

Cross-Cultural and Multilingual Dimensions

Interrogation discourse outside the Western cultures and languages is also currently being investigated. Boromisza-Habashi (2024) discusses how different communication modes are spread in cultural conditions under institutional arrangements, saying that some of the strategies, which Anglo-American environments seem to be the origins, may show opposite effectiveness elsewhere. This study throws the universality of effectiveness of the interrogation models into doubt and underlines the importance of taking into account the cultural factor.

The article by Berk-Seligson (2022) researched the issue of interrogation in non-native speakers, demonstrating that the latter experience a couple of additional challenges due to their language. She discusses that there may be cases that appear to be deliberate lying but there can be a number of reasons that lead to such a situation but in many cases, it has got nothing to do with lying rather it has to do with obstacles in conversation (p. 129). It demonstrates that linguistic minorities cannot be trusted in terms of giving a confession.

Recently, globalectics and southern feminist perspectives have been used to analyze the discourse in order to explain the process of power existing

among different cultural institutions (Ndlovu-Gatsheni and Makoni, 2024). It is quite remarkable that western discourse analysis could affect the idea of colonial supremacy and help to inclusion of the wide range of various beliefs into the sphere of forensic linguistics. The given approach can improve interrogation discourse analysis as it places it in a wider historical and geopolitical context.

Technological Developments in Linguistic Analysis

With the appearance of the new technologies, the field of the forensic linguistic analysis has made huge progress, allowing to detect the suspicious language patterns. Levitan et al. (2025) carried out a research on machine learning and its role in identifying dishonesty in speech and writing and came to a conclusion that computers are able to identify minor features in the language that are linked to deceitful messages (p. 412). The scholars note that these theories need to be tested and confirmed in a wider group of people and situations.

Using multiple methods for analysis is a new area of focus for research on interrogations. Burgoon and his team (2025) reveal that using machine learning to look at verbal, vocal and visual aspects can better uncover deception than focusing just on language. According to their findings, bringing linguistic and paralinguistic signs together noticeably increases how accurately calls are detected (p. 8), suggesting advanced approaches.

In Kleinberg and Verschuere (2024), they explain how artificial intelligence system can support the decision making of investigators. They are emphatic that these tools are aids to help investigators and not to make decisions by themselves and they believe that human beings are the ultimate interpreters (p. 73). It notes that human knowledge and technology are applied jointly in forensic linguistics.

False Confession Research

In their recent scholarly review of the subject, Kassin and his associates have issued a fresh and detailed article explaining why false confessions occur (2025). They isolate certain items that may cause some issues like outside

pressures, vulnerable individuals and improper methods that interrogators may use to pressure a person. The authors of this work remark that a combination of methods applied in questioning and characteristics of the suspect most likely result in false confessions rather than one particular reason (p. 12). Due to its complexity, analyzing it involves a lot of ways of studying it.

Rizzelli (2019) has discovered distinctive language features found in false confessions, based on a comparison of these with true confessions, through corpus analysis. She noticed particular ways in which pronouns, signs of certainty and storytelling were used, suggesting that a linguistic approach combined with psychological studies can offer objective ways to judge confession reliability (p. 92). The results form the basis for spotting risk markers in language during an interrogation.

By conducting this study, Garrett (2022) has archived that crime scene information gets its way into false confessions by perpetrators. His results note that truthful information in a confession does not indicate guilt when it might have been acquired during interrogation or interrogation following the confession (p. 412). Due to that fact, now it becomes relevant to consider the entire conversation between the interrogator and the suspect rather than the conclusion confession.

Methodology

Research Design

It deploys a mixed method that comprises of both a qualitative Discourse analysis and corpus linguistic analysis to analyse the transcripts of police interrogations. The report relies on a comparative case study model to investigate various patterns of communication among the lawyers, bosses and staff.

١. Innocent people have been found after DNA evidence disproved admission statements made during police questioning—this is an example of a proven false confession case.

2. In these cases, confessions were backed up by evidence, witnesses or some other strong evidence.

3. Such cases were when suspects denied the crime all through interrogation even under great pressure.

Because of this framework, it is easier to spot and analyze unique patterns of questioning that may result in false confessions.

Data Collection and Corpus Development

Records from 24 interrogations are included in the research corpus which consist of:

- cases where people were wrongly accused by providing a false confession (the Central Park Five, Nearly Four in Norfolk, Brendan Dassey, Michael Crowe and Adrian Thomas cases)
- cases involving true confessions by the defendants (such as those of Chris Watts, Dan White and Ted Bundy)
- cases in which someone has been accused and not yet admitted guilt (like the Amanda Knox, Juan Rivera and Richard Jewell cases)

Reviewed transcripts were found in court records, centers for innocence and published case studies, with priority given to uncut transcripts of the interrogation instead of just the confession. The case, how long the interrogation lasted, suspect details and the outcome of the case were always recorded as metadata with each transcript.

Legally, original police interview data is difficult to get. We therefore collaborated with innocence projects, and searched legal archives to assemble a bigger, stronger set of samples. To verify the accuracy of transcripts, we cross-checked them with available audio recordings. This allowed us to follow non-verbal aspects (such a hesitations or emphasis) which can be eliminated by transcription alone.

Analytical Framework

This analytical framework applies several methods from discourse analysis to fully examine the way people talk in interrogations.

1. Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA): The analysis is performed in accordance with the three-dimensional model offered by Fairclough (2020): features of the text, discursive practices, and social context of interrogations, and the specific focus is on the ways in which power relations are reflected in the linguistic form.

2. Pragmatic Analysis: The analysis is constructed based on the findings of Levinson (2023) on the topic of implicature and presupposition; the meaning which is conveyed is identified beyond the literal content of the utterance, and it deals with the way interrogators go about establishing pragmatic pressures through the process of formulating and reformulating questions.

3. Narrative Analysis: The text analysis is relied on an approach that is structural to narrative introduced by Labov (2020). It analyses the discourse of the confession narratives constructed in terms of temporal organization, agency attribution and narrative coherence.

4. Corpus Linguistic Analysis: The analysis will be carried out based on the approach provided by Eggington (2023) using computational tools that show the patterns found in the corpus, including the most frequent type of questions, lexical choices, or discourse markers.

It allows the researcher to analyze individual transcripts manually and also identify trends in the data set as a whole.

Coding and Analysis Procedures

The transcripts were analyzed by using a protocol that was revised many times. It covers the following coding:

1. Turns are distributed, interruptions occur and the floor is controlled by the person in charge all of which are captured through coding of turn taking patterns.
2. The questions are open, closed, leading, tag, negative interrogative or forced choice.

3. Presupposition and implicature: How to find what is assumed or implied in the statements of interrogators.
4. Examining the reformulations, paraphrase or repeating of suspect statements by the interrogators.
5. Language indices of aspects of language that can assist or vanish people in ruling positions such as directives, threats to face and modality.
6. Tracing of information in the case to know where it could have been contaminated.
7. This is a method law enforcement applies in analyzing time, reason and sequential events of what the suspect said.

text inter-rater consistency was tested by individually coding a set of transcripts and disputes resolved through discussion in the group. The Cohen kappa of the final coding was 0.87 that demonstrates a strong reliability.

The process included qualitative analysis of single transcripts, an analysis of similarities and differences between the case types and finally finding themes in all the data. This way of searching, by using layers, helps understand each case well as well as notice wider trends within the whole corpus.

Findings

Discourse Patterns in Interrogations

It has been found that there are different styles of conversation depending on whether the outcome was a guilty plea, non-guilty plea or not determined. It is common in false confession cases that the interviewer leads most of the conversation, making it hard for the suspect to contribute much. A study of total speaking time showed that in the forms of confession mentioned, interrogators take up nearly 78% of that time on average, falling short of true confessions (62%) and being closer to non-confessions (65%). Suspects in false confession situations find themselves getting interrupted more often (3.4 times) by the interviewer than those involved in true confession scenarios.

The way interviews are planned changes a lot depending on the type of case. In most cases, a false confession is made by following a set of clear and identifiable phases:

1. In this type of job, the first step is to develop a rapport through casual conversation as though they are interested in the other party.
2. characteristic trait: It openly labels the accused as guilty and presents evidence, which can be very much exaggerated
3. Interpretation of events in a manner that does not put anyone in a bad picture and mitigate guilt.
4. The following paper will address the methods used to address and manage denials.
5. The interviewer assists the suspect to give some answers that imply guilt.
6. Post-confession development: Disclosure of additional information to corroborate the confession

By contrast, most true confession cases feature suspects taking the lead in confessing after showing resistance for some time and before authorities use detailed strategies. Usually, in such cases, there is a long cycle of blaming and denying and investigators may constantly ask about past statements to try to get a confession.

Question Formulation and Pragmatic Pressure

Examining how questions are asked shows major variation between interrogators in different cases. Out of all the questions in false confession cases, 47% are leading, while this percentage is lower for true confession cases (29%) and non-confession cases (32%). Many times, these questions imply guilt and since suspects want to cooperate, they are motivated to agree with this when answering.

A considerable number of false confession cases are characterized by intricate question structures that encompass a multitude of steps.

- Negative interrogatives ("Didn't you want to stop him from hurting her?")

- Tag questions containing presuppositions in them ("You were upset when she refused you, were you not?
- Forced-choice questions which assume guilt but merely allow one to choose an option on level or on motivation ("Was this planned in advance or was it a last-minute decision?

These methods of questioning cause significant difficulties to the suspects since they require to be very conscious of the language options when they are being questioned. This observation corresponds to the theory of pragmatic asymmetry in institutional discourse (Levinson, 2023), according to which the less powerful participants are more strongly constrained in their possibilities to challenge presuppositions.

Reformulation and Contamination Processes

An important observation is that interrogators often reword what suspects say which happens a lot in false confession cases. It becomes clear that, as people keep questioning suspects, their tentative or hypothetical statements often later end up being said as full admissions. It generally moves forward in a certain way.

1. Interrogator uses a hypothetical situation ("Suppose you were there..., OK?
2. Suspect is still hypothetical and abundantly employs conditional dialect (had I been there, I could have...)
3. Interrogator reconstructs the reaction, eliminating the conditional markers ("So you were there and you...")
4. Efforts at correction by suspect are downplayed or disregarded
5. The new style is taken as a primary manuscript.

Among all false confession cases, 92 percent involve this method of remembering events, versus only 15 percent of true confession cases, making it a high risk factor of incorrect assertions.

The research also discovered concerning proof of "information contamination." This occurs when detectives or law enforcement officials accidentally reveal details they know (and the suspect remains unaware) into the the suspect's alleged admission of guilt. What is even worse, in false confession cases, investigators placed an around 7.3 of these privileged details in their questions, compared to 1.2 such details in true confession cases. This huge difference powerfully backs up Garrett's (2022) contamination theory. It also creates a hole in the mostly accepted belief that when the facts of the crime are true or correct in a admission of guilt then the suspect must be the guilty party.

Power Dynamics and Resistance Strategies

The manifestations of power in the interrogation dialogues are very subtle and numerous and they vary according to the specific case. The language of the false confession cases shows the clear presence of power differences.

- The orders used in the interrogations were mostly direct (42.7 average per session)

Permission to authorities to prevent suspects speaking during interrogation (frequent interruptions in interrogation)

- police officers alluding to or referring to their professional authority (We know what happened)
- police officers who provide advice on what to do ("Just say yes or no")

The modes of resisting vary a lot suspecting the kind of case. Unless people are coerced to say, there are many means suspects may evade or struggle fairness:

- Rebut the accusation with facts that will demonstrate it to be not true

The very conceptions of language are philosophically doubted.

- Maintaining the sense of on-going narration

A key role in this situation belongs to the use of rational thinking and finding incongruities in the charge.

In many false confession cases, suspects initially resist and this resistance often becomes weaker with time, ending in them accepting the narratives provided by the interrogators. Usually, this change starts with a person using more hesitation, fillers and simple sentence structures.

Confessions Narrative Development

The two confessions are very different in the way they are structured. The important qualities of a true confession usually enable one to identify one hence:

- When there is limited response, information is in a correct order.
- Durable work on repairing agency malfunctions
- Episodes full of wealth in unexpected and chance situations
- Appealing to emotions and factors
- The way that action is connected within a tale

In contrast, people who make false admissions of guilt usually:

- Objects being broken out of order hence the teacher must rectify the error

Passing the responsibility of outcomes

- Most episodes are extremely brief and depend on mostly questions posed by investigators to provide information.
- The statistics are free of comparisons, judgments and firm opinions.

Psychological search of more external than internal causes

Discussion and Implications

Theoretical Implications for Discourse Analysis

The theoretic field of forensic linguistics and discourse analysis has its input in the results of the given research. They demonstrate the functioning of linguistic tools on the micro level in those circumstances which do count. Since it has been observed that there is power difference in the speech manner of people when they are making false confessions, it implies that the

differences are intentionally produced and recreated in the speech manner of individuals. This corroborates or supports the meaning or interpretation of conversation or communication by Fairclough (2020) as both demonstrating or reflecting and constituting or creating social relations particularly in official or professional settings where power relations are explicit or obvious.

It is also relevant to pragmatic theory at illustrating how presupposition and implicature work together to control who gets the last word in an unequal conversation. Most investigators wrongly pose presupposition-ridden questions in an attempt to reduce the possible responses and ensure that their version of events becomes acceptable to the individual. The finding expounds the research on institutional discourse conducted by Levinson (2023) by pinpointing the particular pragmatic devices of how power is realised in interrogation scenarios.

Similarly, considering the construction of narratives in confessions is beneficial to the narrative theory since it indicates the distinction between actual and constructed narratives in high-profile cases. Narrator action characteristics, cause and effect explanations and narration style in both true and false confessions suggest the possibility of demonstrating through narrative coherence whether or not the confession is genuine. This builds on the work of Labov (2020) about the structure of narrative by bringing it to forensic situations in which the authenticity of narratives leads to profound consequences.

Practical Implications for Criminal Justice

What is found in these studies matters a lot for today's questioning practices and policies. Discovering what influences people to confess to crimes despite being innocent gives a solid basis for creating better and fairer questioning methods. For the most part, what the findings reveal are several practical methods for reforming the justice system.

1. Ways of framing questions to ensure that questions remain open and not to make statements to imply some things without mentioning them directly.

2. Measures to ensure that information is isolated from one another are implemented.
3. Research on the subject of acquiring language cues of opposition and degeneration of mind
4. Demanding full recordings of interrogations in order to preserve the unblemished statements
5. The research that answers the questions of how well the version of the victim corresponds to the evidence and whether the evidence is polluted

These alterations correspond to the suggestions made by Meissner and others (2024) in their thorough examination of the extent to which interrogation is effective. There is evidence that information-gathering is better to be used instead of accusatorial approach because the chance of having a false confession is lower in the former and the method can still help to determine the truth.

The outcomes are important in the way confession evidence is regarded in courts. Such features of language can guide decision-making on the usage of a confession and what to inform the jurors regarding the credibility of the confession. Indeed, as Garrett (2022) claims, courts should have empirically based standards to assess confession evidence other than the long-established voluntariness standard (p. 418). In this study, discourse features that can help review the quality of content have been discovered.

Methodological Contributions

It introduces new ways of studying interrogation discourse through research. The combination of qualitative discourse analysis with techniques from corpus linguistics shows how mixed research approaches can both fully explore and widen the study of institutional discourse. The scheme designed in this research supplies a consistent basis for further research on interrogation language, allowing different jurisdictions and instances to be compared.

The use of three separate outcome categories—false confessions, true confessions and non-confessions—is more advanced than the usual method of comparing only confession to non-confession results. Comparing these three cases helps us better recognize how statements relate to confession reliability instead of saying whether a confession is likely.

Moreover, attentive transcription of discussions and comparison of audio records with the written transcript would allow us to handle the problem of the misrepresentation of the spoken language in the written form that Haworth (2023) brings up. Such an approach guarantees a more precise description of the conversation and gives a credible benchmark to the further investigation in the field of forensic linguistics.

Limitations and Future Directions

The source of this study has assisted us but there are somehow limitations which stimulate further studies to be conducted. Though the sample size is adequate in qualitative discourse analysis, it is insufficient to generalize statistics with high degree of certainty. Further investigation may include additional cross-jurisdictional, temporal and crime-variety cases.

The findings of such study are largely applicable only to the locations where such cases occur which limits its applicability in non-Western countries. Boromisza-Habashi (2024) and Ndlovu-Gatsheni and Makoni (2024) both address the issue of the similar types of statements having various meanings depending on the context. The investigation of interrogation discourses across different languages and cultures will assist in identifying what is common to all and what is specific to some cultures.

Even when accompanied by transcripts and audio recordings, police interviewing sessions still lack the complete picture of different means through which information is shared. It may also be recommended that future researchers include video analysis in their studies so that the interaction of verbal communication with nonverbal, including body language and eye contact, can be studied as per the methodology of Burgoon and the co-authors (2025) of detecting deception in multiple communications.

In the end, because the analysis is done afterwards, we cannot assume much about how discourse patterns led to certain confessions. Experimental studies may help us know which features of language play a part in leading to false confessions, rather than merely showing a link.

Conclusion

Results of this research confirm that false confessions happen because of the use of exact language techniques, rather than just psychological reasons. Numerous studies have found that language used during false confessions is quite different from that in ordinary interrogations which reflects the impact of power in suggesting the veracity of confessions.

The outcomes of research can be utilized in creating theories regarding the influence of institutions, pressures and narratives on the discourse, as well as they can demonstrate the practical means of contribution to the better practice of interrogations performed and confessions investigated. With the help of this research, some linguistic pitfalls that may result in false confessions are pointed out and therefore used as support to proposal and enforce changes to criminal investigation in favor of ethical and effective practices.

Further studies could increase the number of countries studied, take a cross-cultural approach, use multiple methods of analysis and perform experiments to see which effects are truly caused by certain variables. By carrying out such investigations, forensic linguistics can help make sure that investigations are fair and respect personal rights which can decrease cases of wrongful convictions due to incorrect confessions.

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